

FDE Take-Home Assignment

Meridian Systems - Sales Intelligence Scenario

ESTIMATED TIME	TOOLS	SUBMISSION
1-2 hours	Use any tools you have access to	Bring to Interview 2

Background

Meridian Systems sells enterprise software. Their sales org is large and distributed. The CCO and other senior leaders piece together pipeline health from a mix of dashboards and analyst reports, none of which talk to each other.

The data exists. The problem is access. A question like "How is the enterprise segment tracking against quota this quarter?" means either bouncing between dashboards or waiting on an analyst. Decisions slow down. Leaders stop asking.

They tried an AI reporting tool 18 months ago. It hallucinated numbers, mixed up segments, and the CCO called it out in a meeting. There is no formal embargo on AI. But the skepticism is real and it is at the top.

The bar is not just "does it work." It is "can we trust it."

You are coming in as a Forward Deployed Engineer. The client has shared a sample of their sales data and asked a simple question: can we give leaders a faster, more reliable way to get answers?

Your Task

Using the sample dataset (separate download), build an artifact that lets a sales leader ask a plain-English question about pipeline and get back an answer that includes:

- A direct answer. Not a hedge or a redirect.
- The source: the actual data behind the answer, not just "based on your data."
- A flag when the answer involves incomplete data, ambiguity, or a real assumption.

The artifact can be a diagram, a deck, a chat UI, a CLI, a notebook. Whatever format best shows the idea. Use whatever LLM tooling you have.

Dataset

Provided as a separate download. The dataset covers deals, reps, and pipeline stages, with quota targets for both Q1 and Q2 2026.

Q1 (January through March) is final. Q2 (April through June) is in progress as of May 2, 2026. You can ask about closed Q1 numbers, the live Q2 pipeline, or how the two compare so far.

It is small and self-contained by design. No enterprise tool access needed.

Example Queries to Test Against

At minimum, your artifact should handle these:

- "How is the Enterprise segment tracking against quota this quarter?"
- "Which reps are at risk of missing Q2?"
- "How does Q2 attainment compare to where we were at the same point in Q1?"

Deliverables

For your next interview, bring:

1. An artifact of your choosing: prototype, deck, diagram, or something else. Shows the core idea. Rough is fine. Something tangible is not optional.
2. A 5 to 10 minute verbal walkthrough: what you built, what you cut, and what you would do with another 4 hours.
3. A short answer to this: The last AI tool this client used lost executive trust because it hallucinated. How does your approach avoid that problem, and where does it still fall short?

What We Are Evaluating

Not grading on polish. Here is what we are actually looking at:

- Can you build something that answers a real business question under a time constraint?
- Did you make defensible cuts? Can you explain them?
- How do you handle the trust and traceability problem? Not just in code, but in how you would walk a skeptical CCO through it.
- Can you say clearly what your artifact proves, and what it does not?

AI-assisted work is expected and encouraged. How you use it is part of what we are watching.